

WEEK 9 · AGENCY & RESISTANCE

CLASS 1

Agency

READING 1

Accounting for Agency – Valentine

READING 2

A Critical Conversation on Agency – Olsen et al.

Accounting for Agency

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Children are increasingly described as agents and agency is important to arguments for children's rights and participation. Yet agency is rarely defined or theorised in childhood studies. This article reviews common uses and meanings of agency and argues that critical, social conceptualisations have yet to be extensively taken up in childhood studies but offer much to the field. Based on the work of Giddens, his critics and feminist theory, I propose a model of agency that is more ambivalent than that usually presented in childhood studies. Given the conventional emphasis of agency on articulation, rationality and strategy, a failure to incorporate a critical, embodied, engendered, material account of agency into childhood studies risks reinscribing a model in which privileged children will be accorded more agency than those who do not display rationality and choice in conventional ways. © 2009 The Author(s). Children & Society © 2009 National Children's Bureau and Blackwell Publishing Limited.

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Introduction

Children are increasingly described as agents. Does childhood studies¹ therefore need a theory of agency? One answer is that childhood studies does not need a theory of agency, because it already has one: there is a single meaning of agency, and everyone knows what it is. This answer, I will argue here, is incorrect. A second answer is that childhood studies does not need a theory of agency because it is possible to advocate for children's rights and participation (the two arenas in which agency is most often discussed) without it. As the literature on children's agency grows, the tensions and contradictions within it make this answer difficult to sustain. A third answer is that a theory of agency is interesting for theoreticians, but of marginal interest to those advocating for children. In my view, this is misguided and in the concluding sections of this paper I explain why.

My aim here is to make the concept of agency more explicit and visible than it currently is, and to argue that childhood studies is better served by what could be called 'social' models of agency than liberal models.² Childhood studies has begun to take up the implications of a social model of agency in insisting that difference, as well as equality, must be goals of participation. There are other dimensions of these social accounts of agency, I will argue, that are barely emergent in childhood studies, but have the potential to make a lasting contribution to this and other fields of scholarship.

Based on the work of Anthony Giddens, his critics and feminist theory, I will present perspectives that render agency more ambivalent and, I will argue, more promising than its usual characterisation in childhood studies. Childhood studies argues that children demonstrate their agency through competence, strategy and awareness, and that their agency entitles them to greater participation and more rights. Without disputing this, I argue that children's agency must be carefully conceptualised to accommodate, first, the specificity of

different children's lives, second, what is shared between children, and finally what is universal to children and adults. Such a conceptualisation of agency includes non-cognitive and embodied dimensions such as emotion, class, race, disability, language and the physical environment; as well as the rationality and reflexivity promoted by Giddens. It requires acknowledgement of the differences between children, as well as the differences between children and adults.

Recognising children's agency as complex, multidimensional and ambivalent requires that we surrender cherished notions of agency's benefits. In this light, agency cannot be understood as the exercise of authentic choice or self-directed action. There are two reasons why social perspectives are worth these costs. First, theoretical accounts of agency are needed to increase the depth and reach of childhood studies. As James (2007) and Hollway (2006) have argued, childhood studies tends to borrow concepts and methodologies from other disciplines, but in relatively naïve ways. The second reason concerns the coherence of the idea that children are agents more directly. If children are expected to meet the criteria of rational actors presumed by the liberal ideal, then this can only lead to fruitless tests of competence that most children, especially young children, will fail. Some children will pass this test, of course, at least to the degree required of adults, but at the cost of the particularity of the experience of childhood. This is because the liberal model of agency excludes children implicitly where it does not explicitly. To strengthen arguments that children are entitled to both recognition of their *specific* needs and vulnerabilities and recognition of their *universal* capacities, a more nuanced account of agency is needed.

In this article, I present a very brief review of agency in childhood studies, and argue that the meanings of the term are divergent enough to warrant more attention than is normally paid. I then argue that the history of agency is the reason for this divergence, focusing on the three scholarly arenas most important to childhood studies: philosophy, sociology (specifically Giddens's structuration theory) and social movements, especially feminism. In particular, I argue that feminism's emphasis on differences within subordinated groups, as well as between subordinated and dominant groups, is a critically useful insight for childhood studies and has implications for conceptualising agency.

Agency in childhood studies

A growing literature is demonstrating children's agency, especially their competence and knowledge (Corsaro, 1997; Haugen, 2008; MacNaughton and others, 2007; Markström and Halldén, 2008; McDonald, 2008; Smith, 2008). Children have been shown to demonstrate their agency in living with terminal illness (Bluebond-Langner, 1978); making decisions about their medical treatment (Alderson and Montgomery, 1996); dealing competently with each other and adults (Danby and others, 2004); negotiating public spaces (Valentine, 2004); responding to their parents' divorce (Smart and others, 2001); responding strategically to difficult circumstances, such as poverty (Redmond, 2008); and representing the experiences that are important to them (James, 2007).

However, childhood studies also demonstrates divergent understandings of agency. Two examples illustrate this divergence. First, Alderson and others (2005, p. 79) invoke agency in their account of the efforts of premature babies in neonatal intensive care units to breathe, feed and avoid unpleasant stimuli:

The babies' share in promoting and sustaining their basic health care, such as, with difficulty, breathing and feeding, could be taken as evidence of their incipient responsibilities [...] Their *agency* as rights holders was interpreted during our interviews with parents and staff in the babies' positive responses and possible *resistances*: babies' crying out for care, wriggling into a comfortable position.

By contrast, moral philosopher Laura Purdy (1992, p. 121) argues that children are constrained by their developmental maturity. Arguing against the proposition that children should be granted equal rights with adults, she takes up a familiar model of maturity, constituted by:

sufficient self-control to practice enlightened self-interest as well as to subordinate some of one's lesser interests to the stronger ones of others [...] a kind of thoughtfulness about choices that is acquired only by learning, effort and practice.

Purdy argues that while some children may possess this maturity, as a general rule they need time and growth to attain it. Alderson and others emphasise that babies' behaviour should be interpreted as the beginning of agency. Purdy emphasises what, she argues, most children do not have, in advocating that rights-holders should have the capacity for self-awareness and choice that is available only through experience and time. Her account of agency has far more stringent criteria than that proposed by Alderson and others.

A brief intellectual history of agency

Which of the above understandings of agency is the more robust in theoretical and empirical terms? Which is more useful for childhood studies? How does such variation in the meaning of the term emerge? A brief (and very schematic) review of the concept is necessary to begin to address to these questions. To draw somewhat artificial disciplinary distinctions, agency has both philosophical and sociological traditions. Childhood studies draws more directly from sociological uses of the term (but see Castañeda, 2002; Hughes, 1988), but is also indebted to philosophy.

One, minimal, way of defining children as agents is to say that they act purposively. That is to say, they are not only acted upon; and they do not act only according to biological or mechanical programming, as plants and robots do. Clearly, agency is a harder working concept than this in childhood studies, but Alderson and colleagues' account (cited above) appears to draw from this minimal model.

Moral agency requires much more than this minimal model. Within liberal philosophical and political traditions, moral agency is something attained by adults and requires rationality, self-awareness and a sense of futurity. As Hughes (1988, p. 76) writes, children are given short shrift in the classical and early modern political philosophy from which liberalism emerged:

They have an 'immature' deliberative faculty (Aristotle), are not 'endued with Reason' (Hobbes), until roughly the age of 10 (Kant) and are 'incapable of being acted upon by rational consideration of distant motives' (Mill). But they are not completely lost causes. The immature deliberative faculty will mature; children have the 'possibility apparent' of turning into rational beings (Hobbes).

Liberalism is built on a model of individualism in which moral agency is paramount: the sovereign subject, who has attained moral agency, is the basis for arguments that govern-

ments must not be autocratic and tyrannical. This model of agency resembles the one advocated by Purdy (cited above).

Such a model of agency has historically excluded children and to some extent, children are still excluded from it. Young children are not recognised as full moral agents because they have an insufficiently developed sense of consequences and the independent lives of others (Benson, 1990). Very few would argue with the proposition that it is unfair to attribute full moral agency to young children or to those with, for example, psychotic illnesses, because they cannot be held fully responsible for the consequences of their actions.

Liberal traditions, then, appear to be unhelpful for childhood studies, in that they impose criteria for moral agency that most children cannot meet.³ At the same time, all theories of agency, including children's agency, are embedded in these traditions. In particular, the emphasis of childhood studies on children's entitlement to civil participation draws from liberal arguments about the relationship between the state and the individual. Theories of the social contract rest on a relationship between sovereign individuals, who are entitled by virtue of their agency to control how, and the degree to which, they are governed. Liberalism then appears to be to childhood studies 'that which cannot be done without' and so presents particular challenges, to which I will return shortly.

Theories of agency are important because of their account of the capacities of individuals and because of their account of the interaction between individuals and the societies in which they live. They are also important to understanding social change. Giddens's sociological structuration theory (Giddens, 1984) has been enormously influential to each of these arenas, and is perhaps best known for three arguments. First, the supposed choice between agency and structure (do people change structures? Or do structures form people?) is misplaced. Instead, individual agents create and re-create the social institutions in which they live, by acting and making choices within the constraints they face. Second, these choices are often routine and habitual: neither wholly formed by social forces, nor wholly determined by unconscious or subterranean psychological forces, nor freely and explicitly made in all circumstances. Third, competent agents monitor reflexively their own actions and the actions of others. Individuals may not always be able to accurately describe their motivations, but they can generally give an account of why they act as they do, and this will be made in the context of their relationship to others.

Giddens appears to be especially influential in childhood studies which, as noted earlier, focuses on children as competent actors. However, there are two difficulties with settling on structuration and its refinements as a model of children's agency. The first is that Giddens is primarily concerned (in the books on structuration and later) with analysing what, in his view, are transformations in social life: in time-space relations, intimacy, the role of the state, the reflexivity of the body, the family and so on. Counting children into this analysis gives a richer account of these transformations, particularly the role of children in shaping and being shaped by social forces. Recognising children as agents in *this* sense, however, is an analytic rather than normative gesture. It cannot lead to the conclusion that children have been unfairly excluded from participation, or that they are more capable of representing their own interests than is usually supposed, both of which are key goals of many childhood scholars. Computers and IT systems are also (arguably) agents in Giddens's terms (Rose and Jones, 2005). This suggests that if politics is an essentially intra-human concept and the increased civil participation of computers is not (at least for the time being) a serious

question, then a different model of agency is required to argue that agency should be linked to participation.

The second difficulty with structuration as a model for childhood agency is its reliance on more-or-less conscious, rational and self-interested practice. Giddens acknowledges the importance of unconscious motives and unanalysed behaviour, but has nonetheless been criticised for neglecting the non-rational, even apparently self-defeating, aspects of agency, especially for those who have severe constraints on their choices and actions (Ferguson, 2003; Hoggett, 2001). These criticisms are especially relevant for children, whose agency is often seen as impaired precisely because their developmental immaturity is equated with non-rationality and emotion; and whose actions and choices are constrained by their dependence on adults. I will return to these questions, and to the refinements of structuration theory and other contributions to the social model of agency, shortly.

The third significant use of agency comes from social movement studies, which themselves draw on both political philosophy and sociology. Social movement studies demonstrate that subordinated people (including, increasingly, children) act on their circumstances when they are often thought to be passive and without volition. Those who appear to be without agency do make choices within their circumstances. Moreover, those who are privileged appear to have agency in part because their environment suits their needs: rearranging social circumstances to ensure that subordinated groups also have environments that suit their needs would mean that the agency of those groups could be better exercised.

Social movements have a long history of making these kinds of arguments. In 1792, Wollstonecraft (1996: 4.31) argued for the emancipation of women, arguing that women's frailty, dependence and 'shrinking from trials calculated to strengthen their minds' were the result of denial of education and the chance to 'improve'. At the turn of the 20th century, Du Bois (1995) countered arguments about the 'criminality' of the 'Negro' with analyses of social conditions and social stratification. To objections that children are biologically precluded from participation because of their distance from liberal norms of rationality, Freeman (2007, p. 18) notes that the same objections were once made about women (and, it could be added, about men who were not White and propertied).

Contemporary social movements also argue that subordinated groups have agency and that the reorganisation of social structures would let them exercise it. For example, disability activists argue that it is the organisation of social spaces and social norms that is disabling, rather than any inherent quality of the person with disability. Similarly, childhood studies argues that children are excluded from participation because social spaces and conventions are adult-centric and do not allow for children's cognitive and physical particularities. In both cases, it is argued that individuals often regarded as defective or deficient are not the problem. Instead, institutions should be reorganised in such a way so that they enable, rather than prevent, the participation of those individuals (Cockburn, 1998; Uprichard, 2008).

One means of establishing agency is to point to its exercise (as manifested in choice, action and purpose) even in these subordinated circumstances. For example, historical studies of slave women showed that they were resisting even in the teeth of overwhelming oppression, thus countering constructions of them as wholly victimised and acted upon (cited in Benson, 1990). Such constructions emphasise the injustices done to slaves but at the cost of denying them full personhood and active resistance to their oppression. Childhood studies has already

made a distinctive contribution to this body of work in emphasising the competence and capabilities associated with agency, to counter traditional understandings of children as incompetent.

Social movements also make an additional critique of liberal models of agency, which also have potential for childhood studies. Mary Wollstonecraft argued that women could be equal to men, if accorded the same education and expectations. Contemporary feminist (and queer, and anti-racist) theoretical work extends this by arguing that the liberal ideal of disinterested rationality probably cannot be achieved by women, or indeed by most men, but that is because the ideal is unrealistic and undesirable. Alternative models of competence, rationality, relationships and values are needed. These insights from these arguments have already been applied to childhood studies. Lister (2008), for example, explicitly borrows from feminism in proposing a model of 'difference within equality' as a resolution to the dilemmas of meeting both children's rights to equality and their rights to have their specific needs as children recognised. Children are not merely adults (or moral agents) in waiting and their differences from adults should be valued rather than classed as deficiencies.

However, there are other dimensions to these critiques of liberal ideals that have yet to be taken up in childhood studies: in particular, critical responses to Giddens and the importance of intra-group differences.

Agency and the formation of the subject

The 'social model' of agency is a short-hand term. There is no one model and it is not possible to do justice here to each, or indeed any, of the intellectual traditions that have formed it. Giddens's structuration theory is one of these, as are European marxist and psychoanalytic theory (especially Althusserian theories of interpellation and Lacanian theories of subjectification); Foucault's governmentality; and Judith Butler's performativity. Social models of agency are concerned with the relationship between intra-psychic (or internal) and social forces in the formation of the subject and with the importance of agency to the preservation of social norms and hierarchies. Liberalism tends to regard agency as more politically innocent than this. The questions asked by liberalism around agency relate to the legitimacy or illegitimacy of intervention by external forces. By contrast, social models of agency regard agency as inherently political and necessarily the product, in part, of external forces.

In its focus on individual development and social change, these social approaches to agency seem to be ideal for childhood studies, yet the implications of these approaches are rarely taken up. To take a single example, Foucault is often described, quite properly, as a theorist of power whose work is particularly useful for childhood studies. This is because children are included in his classic early studies of governmentality, and because the organisation of children's daily routines and everyday practices represents a paradigmatic instance of the capillary, micro-level exercise of power. Yet taking up only this lesson from Foucault risks a vaguely paranoid, vaguely libertarian account, in which the exercise of power on individuals is detected in more and more settings, but the role of power in forming individuals and individuals' role in enacting and resisting power remains unscrutinised. Foucault was famously emphatic that he was not interested in analysing power as a phenomenon, but the processes by which human beings become subjects (Foucault, 1982). Yet within childhood studies, these processes are paid far less attention than is the exercise of power on children. To put it

another way, the Foucault of *Discipline and Punish* is far more influential in childhood studies than the Foucault of *Hermeneutics of the Subject* or the histories of sexuality.

Perhaps as a consequence, childhood studies tends to assume an 'outside' to the social, or to a space in which children can claim the benefits of agency but not the obligations and ambivalences of political subjectivity. For example, in their account of preschoolers' strategies for agency, Markström and Halldén (2008, p. 2) counterpoise agency with institutionalisation and neoliberal governmentality. Governmentality is presented as agency's other or opposite. Yet governmentality, like structuration, presents agency as implicated far more closely with power than that. Indeed, one of the reasons for the growing influence of governmentality theory is its focus on individual activity and the feedback loops between individuals and power (Hacking, 2002; Rose, 1989). Far from operating in the spaces from which agency is absent, governmentality and agency operate together.

To give another example: Allison James and colleagues conducted a study of children's experiences and perceptions of hospital space. Children participated in a short interview during which they viewed photographs of spaces in the hospital and asked if children would be allowed in spaces of their own. The responses of their informants, they record:

astonished us and are highly revealing of a particular construction of children's potential as active participants [...] the children gave answers that can be summarised as follows: children argue that children, as a category, require supervision in hospital spaces because they are both vulnerable and irresponsible (James and others, 2008, p. 91).

James and colleagues argue that far from 'reflexive and responsible individuals through the range of choices made available within the late-modern 'risk society', children are being increasingly "disabled"' (89, citing Beck, 1992). Yet an alternative, and in my view at least as plausible, reading is possible. The childrens' agency was deployed in their reflexive awareness of relationships and risks, not in their physical exploration of space. They were deploying precisely the risk-management of subjects fully immersed in, and aware of, the risk society described by Beck. It is awareness of risk, after all, that Beck argues is constitutive of a new modernity. (Whether or not the risks posed by the hospital spaces are 'real' or not is another question, of course, but also irrelevant to our purposes here.) Moreover, in claiming the need for chaperones, it could be argued that the children adopted the mantle of a responsible, safe citizen whose awareness of the risks they face constitutes a reflexive self-identity (see Adkins, 2001).

These examples propose an understanding of agency that is more politically inflected than is often seen in childhood studies. Rather than a space in which children can act autonomously, agency is inflected with power, constituted by the social and, as Giddens argues, also constitutes the social. Arguably, this is a less optimistic account of agency than a liberal model: the notion of unconstrained agency is less intelligible here, as are the possibilities for an agency uninflected by the social norms and hierarchies of the dominant culture in which children live. There are other accounts of agency, and childhood studies is now sufficiently mature that different models of agency can be used within it.

My own view is that critical models have a great deal to offer childhood studies, because they oblige an account of agency that is sensitive to differences between children, as well as differences between adults and children. Critical studies of adult agency point to the

importance of class, race, gender and disability in inflecting actions and understanding. For example, studies of impoverished and marginalised ‘welfare subjects’ point out the invidious emotional impact of class and poverty on agency, for example, and the sometimes pernicious effects of practical knowledge and ‘common sense’ (Ferguson, 2003; Hoggett, 2001). People do not always exercise agency in their own best interests – this is true of everyone, but has effects especially for those whose competence and volition is often questioned. Individual trauma and structural oppression may inflect agency in such a way that people act as their own ‘worst enemy’, or act to resist power, and of course resistance to power may be interpreted as self-defeating behaviour. These sometimes uncomfortable dimensions of agency are rarely taken up in childhood studies, which has so far focused on examples of positive, competent, rational activity.

Conceptualising agency in practice

Children’s agency is often discussed in the context of arguments for increased participation: if they are agents, they deserve to participate. This is especially important as children themselves, in the *Minority World*⁴ at least, do not make up a social movement in its classic sense of a group of people making claims on the state. Compared with the large goals of social movements – franchise, land rights, legal recognition – the overall goals of children’s participation and the desired outcomes are relatively indistinct. The emphasis is on process, not outcomes.

Consider, then, the broad principle that children’s agency entitles them to have a say in important decisions that affect them. Querulous mutterings that children should be seen and not heard aside, it is hard to imagine any serious objection to this. However, as a directive to engage children in civil participation it is too broad to be of much use. So a specific example could be children’s contribution to the organisation of their daily routine in school. If a liberal model of agency is assumed here, then children will be recognised as imperfect agents. On this basis, their views may be considered and then discarded, because adults are closer to liberal criteria of rationality and competence, and so are entitled to overrule them. Arguably, this is the mechanism by which children are often consulted now.

Alternatively, a ‘difference within equality’ model argues that specific procedures are needed to ensure that children can contribute. These would allow for differences between child and adult communication skills, literacy, and so on. Rather than viewing children as incomplete adults and therefore incapable of contributing, this model values the differences between children and adults, including the different perspectives they have on what is important. This mechanism is often advocated in childhood studies, which argues that different methodological approaches than those generally adopted in consultation processes may be necessary to engage children, but that children are entitled to be engaged appropriately.

If, however, a social model is used, that recognises the particularity of children and the social embeddedness of the agency of both children and adults, then a far more difficult task arises. Thinking about agency in these terms requires considering not only how children shape and are shaped by school, and the power of adults over children, but also the differences in power and privilege *between* children in school environments. Privileged and disadvantaged children tend to have different dispositions towards school, and the latter group may seem have self-defeating agency around their education, especially as classrooms and curricula have historically favoured the dispositions of privileged children (Bourdieu and Passeron,

1998). Consequently, privileged children may appear to be more amenable to active participation, and to have more constructive agency, than disadvantaged children. Children's agency, moreover, is often directed towards the reproduction of very conventional norms around gender and race and in protecting the status quo rather than transforming social relationships (Davies, 1989; Skattebol, 2003). Research with children in schools and early learning environments demonstrates that even young children are certainly agents, but that their agency incorporates recognition of the relatively rigid identity categories available to them (for example: girls cannot be boys), and incorporation of the social norms and rules that make up these categories.

This social model of agency is then a more ambivalent affair than traditional liberal models. It argues that agency is an achievement of the subject, and the product of power, and so renders problematic the notion of 'free choice' or 'autonomous activity'. This is not to say that choice is illusory or that agency is nothing more than the product of environment. It does insist, however, that the actions and dispositions that constitute agency, including 'choice' and 'competence', are not politically empty or neutral categories. Instead, the actions and dispositions of children become, in this approach, mutable, contingent and meaningful: revealing both the role of individual agency in reproducing social norms and the potential for individual agency to disrupt them.

More importantly, the criticisms of traditional liberalism offered by this account do seem necessary to childhood studies. Longstanding feminist traditions point out that agency, as it is traditionally understood, is most easily achieved by individuals with particular social privileges, such as education, which have been traditionally granted to men. Newer feminist traditions point out that this kind of agency can be achieved by some women, if they too gain access to those social privileges, but that making all women the same as men in the name of agency is neither possible nor desirable.

These hard-fought lessons seem relevant to childhood studies, especially as the idea that children have agency is increasingly accepted. There are at least two dimensions to this. First, our understanding of children's agency should not require them to be like adults. This is well recognised in childhood studies. Second, and far less recognised, our understanding of children's agency should not require them to have the social privileges that have traditionally been understood as bestowing adult agency. In the absence an analysis of the inflections of privilege and disadvantage in forming agency, those children who approach most closely liberal ideals will appear to have most agency, and therefore appear to be most entitled to participation. Given the conventional emphasis of agency on articulation, rationality and strategy, a failure to incorporate a critical, embodied, engendered, material account of agency into childhood studies risks reinscribing a model in which privileged children will be accorded more agency than those who do not display rationality and choice in conventional ways.

Conclusion

This article has presented arguments for the incorporation of critical social perspectives into conceptualisations of children's agency, and I have used the term 'social models' of agency as a short-hand to indicate what these incorporations may produce. What impact could these accounts of agency have on childhood studies, and what would be the consequences were they taken up? There are at least two changes these conceptualisations could bring to the

field. The first is to complicate the proposition that agency is straightforwardly a personal capacity or attribute, which is how childhood studies sometimes tends to treat it. Agency is not the same as competence or capability, and proving that children have agency is not the same as proving they are entitled to greater participation or rights. This first implication, then, is to sound a note of caution about the uses of agency.

The second contribution that the critical social perspectives reviewed here can make is in analysis of the differences between children. As is well known, discourses about children as social investment or risk, in which they are accorded most importance as future adults, are much more influential in policy and politics than discourses about children as beings in their own right. At the same time, genuine efforts are being made to recognise children's capacity to participate in research and policy, and to recognise children as agents. Critical perspectives on agency seem necessary to ensure that privileged children are not recognised as agents and therefore entitled to participate, to the exclusion of less privileged children.

Recognising children's agency as inevitably inflected with the social, reflecting the hierarchies in which they live, appears to be a troubling possibility for childhood studies. However, much has already been achieved in troubling conventional standards of agency and making the case for a more generous, comprehensive series of standards. There is much to be gained in extending these gestures. A critical account of agency requires that the concept do more work than establishing that children are capable of willed action and are competent in specific situations. However, it also promises a more clear-eyed understanding of the agency of both children and adults, and the forces that constitute and disrupt existing social relationships.

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Notes

1 This is an umbrella term for interdisciplinary research on children, also called the new sociology of childhood.

2 The 'social model of agency' is my own, inelegant, term. In using it I do not mean to suggest that liberalism and other traditions disregard the social.

3 Whether or not *adults* meet them is, of course, an open question, and one that has been subject to robust discussion in childhood studies.

4 There are a number of children's social movements in the Majority World, such as the child worker movement in India.

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Object Lesson

STEPHANIE OLSEN, KRISTINE ALEXANDER,
SUSAN MILLER, VILLE VUOLANTO, SIMON
SLEIGHT, MISCHA HONECK, SARAH EMILY
DUFF, AND KAREN VALLGÅRDA

A CRITICAL CONVERSATION ON AGENCY

STEPHANIE OLSEN

It is no surprise that debates about agency play out in the history of childhood and youth. Children and youth are among the most marginalized actors because of their minority and because of various intersecting categories—class, race, gender, sexuality, religion, disability—that often leave them without a strong say in their own lives. Yet historians of childhood and youth have been some of the most vocal in articulating a discomfort with the concept of agency. Recent scholarly debates over the usefulness of agency as a tool for understanding change over time have pointed to its limitations: it tends to privilege certain kinds of resistance over more complex analyses of people’s responses to change; in doing so, it leaves out certain categories of people unable to participate in resistance narrowly defined. Key interventions by historians of childhood have suggested that the conventional formulation of agency needs replacing or at least redefining.¹ This work builds on seminal interventions by historians of race, slavery, and gender.²

The focus has mainly been on the limits of the concept, with calls for its fine-tuning or even for its complete rejection. Agency has demonstrated itself to be a resilient and appealing concept, though, despite the continued negative attention. In part, I surmise, this is because there has not been a case made for other concepts that can replace it or fulfill its analytical role with a similar convenience but with fewer criticisms. Ishita Pande’s provocative question in response to Sarah Maza resonates loudly here: “Does the child vanish with the onset of agency?”³ Our fundamental question as historians of childhood and youth, about age as a contingent but meaningful category itself, seems to be tied up with the problematic search for agency.

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This article features in conversation leading scholars in the field, all of whom have pondered and problematized agency in different national and colonial contexts, each with something distinctive to say from various subdisciplinary and geographical perspectives. Our discussion stems from a roundtable, part of the Academy of Finland Centre of Excellence in the History of Experiences conference on *The History of Experience and Agency: A Critical Intervention* (HEX 2021).⁴ We point to potential pitfalls of agency from various theoretical, methodological, and political perspectives and, in an attempt to move away from or at least to rethink agency, discuss potential alternative routes out of the “agency trap.” A novel reformulation of the category of experience figures prominently in theorizing these alternatives.⁵ Recent trends in this new history of experience seem to be entwined with the critical discussion on agency, to the point of letting it go. With this and other potential paths away from a focus on agency, historians of childhood and youth might retool to get the analytical results for which we strive from our archives and historical actors.

Our conversation here draws out the various ways that we have problematized agency, the various reservations we have about the concept and the various solutions we have thought through. For some of us, “agency” does not simply need to be replaced as a concept with another similar one, but rather we need to reframe how we approach the history of children’s voices and power, as well as how “the child” is historically constructed and shaped. Is there a clear distinction, theoretically or methodologically, between agency and “children’s voices?”⁶ We ask what it is that we are trying to “get at” with agency and how we can reformulate these goals with a refined understanding of agency or with other tools entirely. We ask why this is a particularly pressing issue for historians of childhood and youth, but we also probe the extent to which this should be an issue for all historians, suggesting that new insights from our field can contribute to historical methodology more widely. We explore what a new analytical framework without agency might mean for the history of childhood and youth and how we might begin to rethink other critical analytical categories within the field. How might the categories of emotion, sensation, and experience push us to reconsider questions of power, structures of authority, and social categorizations such as gender, class, age, and race?

To riff on Mona Gleason’s question in her HEX 2021 keynote address, in what ways were/are young people in the past historically significant (with or without agency)?⁷ No human of any age is fully agentic or independent, or static at any point in their lives. The new history of experience tries to get at this changeability and interdependence of individual and collective selves

historically.⁸ It is a call for the meticulous understanding of particular contexts and their actors and for renewed attention to the empirical handling of archival material, to provide a more complete picture of collective and individual experience, always keeping in mind the question of power. By changing the questions we ask of our sources, we might acquire more complete and satisfying stories to tell.

The leading historians here showcased seek out new approaches either to critically hone or else depart from agency. This conversation has helped us to think productively about the concepts of agency and experience. We hope it will stimulate debate and novel approaches to inform our own work and that it will prove useful to other historians of childhood and youth as well.

KRISTINE ALEXANDER

My relationship to the concept of agency has changed over the past several decades, moving from fascination to frustration and—most recently—to the realization that, as a scholar interested in young people, gender, and colonialism, I need to employ other analytical tools to do justice to my subjects. My thinking owes much to the work of Mary Jo Maynes and Lynn M. Thomas. Writing girls' history, Maynes argues, forces us to reckon with the limits of agency and its implicit, generally unquestioned reliance on modern, Western, enlightenment-based understandings of selfhood, action, autonomy, and rational choice.⁹ Thomas, meanwhile, emphasizes the limits of what she calls "agency as argument": the tendency to frame the demonstration of a subaltern group's agency as the "defining contribution" or central thesis of a piece of scholarship.¹⁰ While describing agency as an inspiration, a bugbear, and a "conceptual lynchpin" in her own research fields, Thomas laments the ubiquity of agency as argument—which she characterizes as "evidence of a limited intellectual imagination."¹¹

Agency as argument is a central tenet of the historiography of young people in a range of national contexts. In Canada, the settler-colonial state where I live and work, this fact is inseparable from the history and ongoing legacy of Indian residential schools, the genocidal church-run and government-funded institutions that took an estimated 150,000 Indigenous children from their families between the mid-nineteenth and late twentieth centuries.¹² In these carceral spaces, Indigenous children encountered racist policies, hunger, abuse, disease, and death. Residential schools caused immeasurable intergenerational suffering, but they also ultimately failed in their mission to obliterate Indigenous languages, cultures, and family ties.

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In Canada, the historiography of childhood and youth evolved largely separately from scholarship about Indigenous history and residential schools, with the result that much of the field still remains—in Mary Jane McCallum’s words—“isolated from Indigenous scholarly critique.”¹³ While some historians of childhood began to express discomfort with the concept of agency in the early twenty-first century, a foundational critique of its effects on Indigenous history was made in the 1990s by Canadian settler historians Robin Brownlie and Mary Ellen Kelm. Historical scholarship that focuses on Indigenous agency, they argued, risks “us[ing] evidence of Native resilience and strength to soften, and at times to deny, the impact of colonialism, and thus, implicitly, to absolve its perpetrators.”¹⁴

More recently, Indigenous historian Crystal Gail Fraser has emphasized the limits of conventional applications of “agency” in her award-winning study of residential schools and Indigenous communities in the Canadian arctic. Focusing on the actions, choices, and responses of Indigenous youngsters and their families, Fraser uses the work of Eve Tuck, Avery Gordon, and Michel Foucault in combination with Dinjii Zhuh concepts of strength in an analysis that foregrounds northern Indigenous voices and perspectives. She writes that Tuck’s determination to “explore the ‘complexity, contradiction, and self-determination of lived lives’ inspired me to reject tiresome arguments about the ‘agency’ (or lack thereof) of my ancestors and relatives.”¹⁵

Scholars, in other words, need to think carefully about the political and ethical stakes involved in applying conventional understandings of agency to contexts like these. Fraser’s work does exactly this: writing about Grollier and Stringer Halls, two residential schools in the Canadian Arctic that were only closed in the late 1990s, she notes that few scholars have thought to investigate the agency of settlers in these carceral colonial contexts. In Canada, additionally, historians of young people have generally neglected to explain their (often white) subjects as the products and beneficiaries of settler colonialism.¹⁶

I have found the work of Holocaust historian Michael Rothberg to be extremely useful as I—a white scholar who continues to benefit from settler colonialism—grapple with the active not-knowing about residential schools and genocide (another type of agency?) that characterizes much Canadian social history as well as Canadian society more broadly.¹⁷ Rothberg suggests that implication is a useful way to understand “the manifold indirect, structural, and collective forms of agency that enable injury, exploitation, and domination but that frequently remain in the shadows.”¹⁸ Implication, in other words, is a collective and not necessarily conscious form of agency through which some people—including white settlers of all ages—“contribute to, inhabit, inherit, or

benefit from regimes of domination” without originating or controlling these regimes.¹⁹ It offers enormous potential for historians of young people and colonialism to understand the people we study—and our own lives—in more nuanced and accurate ways.

SUSAN MILLER

Like several other colleagues here, I grappled with the concept of agency in the context of researching children who were members of voluntary youth organizations. To say that neither the young members nor the adult leadership were monolithic does not begin to tell the story. Children flouted and followed rules. Some adults enforced institutional norms; others behaved as if they had never read a mission statement in their lives. I do believe that it can be productive to consider all of those varied reactions as a form of agency, as people expressing their ideas and opinions, giving vent to feelings and emotions, and in doing so, leaving a trace of themselves behind. As all of us who research youth can attest, many of these inclinations created only the faintest of reverberations in the historical record. Indeed, most of us leave a mere shimmer of ourselves behind. Yet these past lives can be felt and affirmed. Studied, and in one small sense, reclaimed. It’s why many of us chose to become historians, to seek out those glimmers. I do think about this shimmer of life—fixed like some fragile flower pressed between worn pages—as the stirrings of agency.

As is so clear from this conversation and the previous work of my colleagues here, as well as the scholarship of so many others, agency has drawn intense scrutiny in the past few years. This intensive examination is well deserved. We have been warned of “traps,” cautioned about agency’s historical roots, asked to view the concept on a continuum, admonished to take care in defining exactly what we mean by the term, and urged to never see the identification of agency as an end in itself. After all these warnings, I can also appreciate why some colleagues have turned away from the concept altogether. But I am reluctant to throw away a tool, just as it is being so carefully honed.

In mulling over the questions that animated this conversation, I was reflecting on how often I reach into my former life in the history of science for parallels to think about agency itself as well as how to search for it in archives. I believe we can productively think about agency as a force. Perhaps what works for planets can work for people if we continue to develop ingenious methods of indirect observation. Most exoplanets cannot be directly observed, so faint is the light they reflect. But their presence is detectable by observing their ability to interact with other objects—we “see” them when they interfere with orbits and tug, ever so slightly, on other, larger bodies. The task of finding and

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understanding these very real bodies requires a focus on subtle gravitational forces. I don't find it too much of a stretch to equate the search for children in archival sources to this astronomical exploration.

Contemplating agency as akin to gravitational force helps to answer some of the charges leveled against the utility of the concept. The force of agency is inherently relational, and it need not be generated as an expression of individualism or autonomy. As I've written about previously, agency certainly doesn't necessarily equate to rebellion. When exerted by historical figures that have been marginalized and disenfranchised, the force may be ephemeral, yet it still changed something and was felt by those in proximity. In the archives of youth organizations, I've found the letters, diaries, and scrapbooks of girls who clearly believed that they occupied an interconnected world that they shared with peers and adults—some like-minded, some they disliked. Sources such as these do call out to us to broaden our theoretical perspective and to apply insights from the history of emotions, and the history of experience. But within these sources I have also seen a force of will.

Recently, I visited the Opie Collection at Oxford University. It is a vast compendium of children's folklore, mainly though not exclusively from post-World War II British youth. What struck me most in browsing the collection of songs, slogans, and slang was the display of children's assertions of relational power. They came up with dozens of names for peers they disliked, and "yells" to honor those they admired. They created rituals to celebrate small victories over teachers, truant officers, and bullies. And they repeated, or coined, slang to describe their world and police the people—adults and other children—who occupied it. They created and enforced rules around truth-telling, property rights, the telling and keeping of secrets, and the intricacies of teams and truces. Their rhythms and rules enforced racial, class, religious, and gender stereotypes and occasionally subverted them. I cannot imagine writing about the sources in this collection without invoking the concept of agency.

What I have taken away from myriad discussions of agency over the past few years, and what I believe this conversation further proves, is that the concept of agency is in good hands. It would be sheer hubris to suggest that we can no longer fall into traps, but the careful reflexivity that many historians of youth deploy when invoking the concept is heartening. We question our own backgrounds and biases as carefully as we pour over archival records. What we find in those records is that children and young people act and assert their wills. Their actions as they move through the world affect those around them, knocking adults slightly out of their established orbits, if only fleetingly.

VILLE VUOLANTO

Around fifteen years ago, “agency” emerged as a slippery but useful concept that guided me to see how little the research on premodern childhood had been interested *in* children, instead of *views* on children. Agency offered a dynamic alternative to “socialization,” itself a new concept in the research of ancient children at that time.

However, with the “agentic turn,” the concept was interpreted in perplexingly different ways. This led to a common but misleading idea(l) that agency should imply significant actions, even “historical change,” where, in turn, *historical* meant an impact on the progress of (liberal) society and culture. To protest and to rebel would always be more positive and more agential than reproducing social norms and life. Complying or acting in the interests of continuity are seldom understood as agential, as historians easily slip a priori into looking for promoters of change and deviations from social norms. Can there be agency in obeying parents to go to bed on time, to work in the family field, or to study as instructed?

“Agency” is often seen to equal autonomous will and action, social capital, and an individualistic worldview—thus, an unsuitable concept for understanding childhood in the remote past. Here we encounter a basic dilemma of social history and social sciences: the question of the primacy of (individual) agency or of (social) structures. Recognizing this when discussing children and youth agency would lead to a more relaxed stance toward agency in general: the lack of capacity of “autonomy” in children is only marginally different than for any (adult) individual. Without doubt, actors in the past have had many restraints—no individual is impervious to the dominant culture and its discourses. Our experiences, actions and reactions, beliefs and memory, strategies and hopes inevitably depend on many layers of cultural, bodily, and discursive factors in a particular historical setting. Would it not be exactly because of this interplay among individuals, structures, and constraints that agency should be studied in the first place?

In thinking about limits for agency in children and youth, we are dealing with differences in degree, not in kind—we may never know how well internalized an individual’s acceptance of cultural conventions is, and historians’ lack of “authentic voice” for children is qualitatively no different than that of adults. Rather than seeking individual competence or strategic planning in agency, a more fruitful—and equal—viewpoint to understand agency would be to place it in social networks and in structures of power. Agency is not individual, but shared, “in-between and interstitial” as David Oswell has stated.

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What is relevant for agency is not change, but choice. Change would again marginalize the everyday lives and experiences of (most) children. For there to be the possibility of choice, individuals need to reflect on their situation consciously, with an intention, or goal, in the subsequent (re)action—that is, there is an ability to act differently, a possibility of making a difference, as Anthony Giddens has put it.²⁰ If we hold agency aiming at “mere” survival, adaptation, and compliance in social interaction as secondary, we undermine the scope for social and cultural agency. Yet without linking agency to intentionality and choice as self-expression, the concept loses its interpretative power. As Mustafa Emirbayer and Ann Mische have written, agency is always *towards* something, a means of entering into a relationship with one’s context: persons, places, meanings and events.²¹

This goal seeking should be seen as a mundane, even haphazard way of making everyday choices. It should not be confused with the gaze of the scholar, who may track patterns from such choices and see them forming a variety of social and cultural strategies—for survival, social capital and advancement, and, more generally, for continuity. Historical actors themselves may not have “felt” they had agency, even if scholars may interpret the behavior they observe as goal-oriented patterns of agency—that is, as life strategies.

Focusing on choice would allow agency to be a fruitful concept in historical studies. It would prevent us from undermining the culture of children, allowing us to take their actions (and limitations) seriously. We should accept that having significance and making a difference in one’s everyday interaction is “enough” and that this significance is assessed through children’s own experience and culture. Moreover, the multiplicity of childhoods due to different variables—gender, age, birth order, health, differences in socioeconomic status and family structure, variation in religious beliefs and practices, and regional and ethnic circumstances—impacted children’s lives, experiences and (limited) agency. This intersectionality needs to be taken seriously.

Agency offers a way to shift the focus from adult viewpoints and representations to the lived reality and experiences of children. It directs our gaze to children’s interests, highlighting the possibility of choice and of making a difference. By searching for children’s agency, we may be able to find new perspectives on power structures, life strategies, and resiliency, or, in other words, a “childist perspective,” with an intersectional take on children and childhood agency. However, for ancient history, for example, this would often signify research on borderline conditions for agency rather than on agency itself. Thus, for me agency is a theoretical concept in the original sense of the term (Greek *theorein* = to look at, to view): I use it to see with new eyes. For a nuanced

analysis of the sources, more subtle methodologies and concepts are certainly needed. In my case, this has led me to concepts such as social strategies and experiences. But this is not a question of choosing between agency *or* experiences: any agency begins with an experience, and any clearly defined conceptual tool can help us to understand the world around us.

SIMON SLEIGHT

Until recent years, I must confess, I did not really worry about the intellectual legitimacy of agency. I was interested in social actors as historical agents, and it followed that those agents must have had agency. But in response to mounting critiques of the term, I started to think more purposefully about how agency was deployed and about how I might seek to reframe or transcend it. It quickly emerged that agency often lacks definition and that it has tended to be conflated (as Mona Gleason and others have identified) with rebellious acts, often performed by male adolescents, and onto which have been read political motivations.

For me, however, agency was always more subtle. It was not necessarily a stone being flung through a window, but more akin to modes of self-assertion—for instance, agency as *self-presentation* (including within tight disciplinary contexts that would seem to preclude it), through forms of *movement* and the decisions entailed by that movement (such as where children chose to play, with whom, and with what), in *assent* to adult-sanctioned activities like cadetship or calisthenics, and associated with what young people chose, or were encouraged, to *write down or otherwise self-fashion*. The dynamics and constraints of power were never far away from these conceptions.

Gleason rightly criticizes scholars for seeing agency as an end in itself. Combined with the ill- or un-defined nature of agency, its tendency to pit youth against adults (while also seeking out adult-like activities), its apparently undifferentiated nature, its gendered dynamics, its valorization of rebellious rather than consensual acts, and its Western, individualistic roots, this is the heart of the case against agency so neatly outlined.

Yet there is a danger with the ongoing agency debate of churning round and round without really moving forward—of being stuck within an eddy in a river of words. It is worth remembering, too, that even in some of the most searching critiques of agency, including by David Lancy (who offers the departure point for Gleason's journal article), a *reframing* of agency rather than wholesale abandonment is proposed—"I urge readers," Lancy concluded, "to not praise children's agency nor bury it but, to tackle it with all the empirical weapons in our arsenal."²² Further, some academic contributions—including from geographers

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and social studies scholars—yield potential answers to several of the conceptual problems later raised (or raised in parallel) by historians.²³ Agency, it transpires from such wider reading, can be more generous as a concept than its sharpest critics admit.

Nonetheless, agency has a rival. Experience is a blood relation of agency, but more capacious and thoroughgoing. With experience there are fewer concerns about an imbalanced focus on youthful politicized or otherwise spectacular activity, or potential confusions about youthful self-expression as an all-or-nothing act. But what does experience really mean? And how might it help us comprehend histories of childhood and youth more deeply?

Experience is for me is the feel and the fabric of everyday life—the inhabited *texture* of the past that resides in between context (as defined by Quentin Skinner) and text (following Roland Barthes). This texture, as I wrote in a chapter on the concept of “plasticine cities,” is something that we can seek to recover and analyze through drawing on a wide array of source types.²⁴ Far from being confined to the realm of linguistics, experience is instead sensory, subjective, temporal, spatial: a way of knowing and being in the world.

To continue to unpack experience, one can draw on informed guides. For Norman Fischer, experience is “more than the mechanical register in consciousness of a perception”; it is, rather, an evidenced activity set in a particular place and time and an inner awareness of “thoughts, feelings, sensations, moods, intentions, desires.”²⁵ This delineation taps usefully into the “emotional turn” within historical scholarship and emphasizes the grounded nature—the spatial basis—of experience. Whatever one’s age, moreover, there is no need to be “agentic” to have experiences like those noted by Fischer, albeit that such experiences are argued to accumulate across the life cycle and are not unconstrained. In an earlier framing by Yi-Fu Tuan, experience is a term for “the various modes through which a person knows and constructs a reality,” tinted once more by emotion.²⁶ Again there is an emphasis on the sensory here, as well as a holistic interest in ways of being.

In any re/turn to experience within the history of children and youth and beyond, there will be works to rediscover as well as new ground to explore. Building onto earlier accounts greater appreciation of the intersectional, the sensory, the embodied and the emotional, as well, I would advocate, as retaining a focus on the spatial dimensions of life, experience can offer a fruitful way out of the swirling agency trap. We might commence, just perhaps, by considering young people’s “formative experiences.”

Whatever we advocate, agency is—for good or ill—likely here to stay. So, alongside experience, we might need to learn to live with agency and to bend

it into better shape. It is certainly no longer enough to treat traces of agency as an amateur archaeologist might treat fragments of china: something to dig out, collect, and display for their own sake. Instead, historians should seek to understand how it was to inhabit the past, the worldviews and domains of our historical subjects, and changes big and small. Here's where experience—our own, as well as that of our historical subjects—is again potentially useful as an organizational framework. Let's see.

MISCHA HONECK

I have had three major encounters with agency so far: first as a laughingstock, then as a zombie, finally as a serious concept. When I enrolled at Heidelberg University in 1998, I was joining a fairly conservative history program. My professor, a traditional diplomatic historian, did not hide the fact that he despised social history. To him, agency was something for people who have nothing to say writing about people who had nothing to say.

Then I started hanging out with social and cultural historians, all disciples of the Bielefeld School. Avid readers of Michel Foucault, Marc Bloch, and Hans-Ulrich Wehler, they viewed history as an assemblage of panoptic webs of discipline and power, not as the product of people charting their own destinies. I always found this ironic: while some historians of the West were busy declaring agency dead, non-Western scholars gave it a new lease on life. I'm speaking, of course, of the postcolonial turn and the histories of disenfranchised groups it inspired. The spillover effects of this debate were substantial. Our reflections on agency and experience would be much impoverished today without postcolonial reframings of the past.

For me, agency was never a holy grail. I never doubted that my young people were agential beings. The questions I asked were somewhat different—how were they agential? Why does it matter? Agency debates from slavery and postcolonial studies cannot be simply superimposed on the study of children. I am a historian of organized youth, writing histories both of and through young people, to borrow Sarah Maza's phrase for a moment. The founders of this branch of historical inquiry didn't really appreciate that young people were actors. The sources, to be sure, tell a different story. My boys simply wouldn't stand still, wouldn't shut up. The Americanist Jay Mechling was on to something when he described youth organizations as syncretic cultures, which manifested themselves in the "struggle between adult intentions and youth's desire to exercise as much autonomy and agency as possible."²⁷ Mechling got half of it right, but the struggle part wrong.

What I found was that in scouting, boys too acted as agents of transformation: not just in relation to themselves, their own journey up the imagined

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ladder of masculine development. Their doings were also vital for the agency of adults, especially for men who were in the process of carving out for themselves a new kind of selfhood. The youngsters had something adults wanted, which gave them influence beyond their years. I proposed the term “boyification” to describe the organization’s intergenerational dialectic.²⁸ Men sought to masculinize boys but also hoped to get something in return: the lost innocence and purity of boyhood, which they hoped to reclaim through performances of homosocial, cross-age solidarities.

Boyification disrupted common conceptions about the relationship of aging and time. It was not just the boys who grew into men—the men, too, sought to transform, to rejuvenate themselves. Their performance depended on the kids’ participation to work; it needed their “approval” to acquire credibility. This made me think of age and childhood less in terms of fixed stages on a linear trajectory of aging. More than just constructs, both need to be understood as social performances as well.

Performances, however, go awry, and they rarely yield the results intended by those in charge. Is this agency? Is this experience? Or is this something else entirely? Let me propose a concept that is still underutilized in childhood studies—*Eigen-Sinn*! My guess is that few English-language scholars have encountered the term before, let alone in the context of childhood studies. There are understandable reasons for that. The concept is notoriously German. It is hard to define and even harder to translate. Some liken *Eigen-Sinn* to a planet in the solar system of agency, but it rather resembles a comet streaking right through it. In a rare English-language glossary entry, Lüdtke described *Eigen-Sinn* as “a kind of self-affirmation, an act of (re)appropriating alienated social relations . . . by self-assertive prankishness, demarcating a space of one’s own.”²⁹

At best, *Eigen-Sinn* can teach us to appreciate modes of action and reaction that may seem trivial because they spring from impulses that are different from the dictates of group loyalty but also diverge from the logic of permanent separation. These impulses carry important lessons: that there are realms of ungovernability in institutions, no matter how tightly regulated or “total” their rule; that the *Eigen-Sinn* of even their smallest members can (de)stabilize existing power relations; and that straying from the script is not tantamount to abandoning it.

Looking back at my work on the Boy Scouts, *Eigen-Sinn* turned out to be a much more effective instrument for getting a grip on my young actors than any holistic concept of agency. I just wish I had applied it more thoroughly. This is not to say that the approach is without blind spots or limitations. Buying into *Eigen-Sinn* means buying into microhistory, with all its pros and cons. Still, I

believe that *Eigen-Sinn's* assets far outweigh its liabilities. It accommodates the kind of spontaneity, impulsivity, ambiguity, and fleeting anarchy that flourishes outside rigid conceptions of individual and collective identity. Boy Scouts saluted, cheered, and embraced their elders as “brothers.” But they just as often snickered, yawned, burped, messed around, and, much to the men’s irritation, flirted with girls. More often than not, I found them darting sideways, lingering in the rear, or racing ahead—only to fall back in line. They did all this and still did not vanish into something else. Perhaps the child is the father of man after all.

SARAH EMILY DUFF

The concept of agency is where my two fields of scholarly research coincide. It is agency defined as resistance to authority that links scholars interested in Africa and in children and young people. For historians of Africa, this project of seeking out agency-as-resistance in the archive is linked to the emergence of the field in the 1950s and 1960s, as graduate students and early career academics allied their work to the decolonial movements sweeping the continent during these decades. But especially since the early 1990s, historians have reflected seriously on this emphasis on histories of resistance—and on the implications of defining agency *only* as resistance. Drawing on scholarship produced by the Subaltern School, anthropologists, as well as with historians of enslavement, scholars of Africa like Frederick Cooper and Lynn Thomas have argued that an overemphasis on overt, violent resistance to the colonial state makes nearly every other kind of activity look like collaboration, and it does not capture the textures of everyday life under colonial rule. Indeed, agency itself has become the argument for many historians: “proving” the agency of Africans becomes the purpose of historical research.³⁰

Scholars of Africa have long been attentive to age categories and for many reasons, ranging from the crucial significance of generation in structuring many societies across the continent to the importance of youth activism in ending colonial rule and shaping postcolonial states. And yet an emphasis on agency understood only as active resistance has produced a limited definition of who constitutes the “youth.” Abosede George asks: “The overwhelmingly male focus of the study of youth in the African history field raises the question: Where are the girls?”³¹ In addition to this, she notes that historians should be attentive to the changing ideology of childhood. The colonial project itself was justified via the humanitarian construct of the “African child”: always the victim of careless parents but also always potentially the agent of violent disorder, the “African child” needed the careful, nurturing interventions provided by the

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infrastructures of education, medicine, and, indeed, punishment implemented under colonial rule. Similarly, Ishita Pande describes how the establishment of normative age categories in colonial India was crucial for the making of the “empty” time of a nascent Indian nationhood. Colonial rule produced “childhood” as a category through which to govern; equally, stable chronological time was a useful tool with which to build an Indian nation.³²

Additionally, a normative, “Western” understanding of agency as fully autonomous action, usually in aid of increasing the freedom and well-being of the subject, does not help to understand the functioning and negotiation of age and power on the continent, especially during the pre- and early colonial eras. In many societies across Africa, generation in intersection with factors like gender and free or unfree status was a crucial vector of power.³³ This generational system of ordering societies placed all people into age cohorts, meaning that everyone operated within the obligations and norms associated with being a particular age. Although children certainly constituted an important age category within African societies, they were at the bottom of a social scale that used age to apportion more power to those at its top than to those lower down. Of course, these systems varied over time and space and were not absolutely rigid—but nobody was exempt from the meanings associated with belonging to an age group, neither adults nor children.

Historians would do well to heed Thomas’s suggestion that historicizing agency is a vital task.³⁴ But even more than this, locating agency within pre-colonial generational systems is not necessarily the most interesting or revealing strategy for understanding how children and young people—and who we might mean by these categories has to be carefully defined—lived in these worlds. Colonial rule altered these age-based systems and overlaid them with Western ideas about childhood that were, too, shaped by the racial dynamics of the enforcement of colonial rule. The consequences of this enormous change were as varied. Generational conflict between younger and older people often mapped onto economic and political discontent, producing revolts against the colonial state and the patriarchal order. Less spectacularly, children moved between these worlds, often acutely aware of the different sets of expectations and the degrees of freedom applied to them in those contexts. In various contexts, they were “older” or “younger,” existing in relation to adults in different ways.

What these examples attest to is the necessity of understanding how children and young people found their ways within these systems. My engagement in histories of childhood has been through the lens of Protestant evangelicalism, so I have had to redefine what counts as agency in a context where believers both seek their own submission as well as go out to encourage the conversion

of others. Indeed, children were held up by evangelicals as the ideal Christians precisely because of their apparent powerlessness. But as records pertaining to children's experiences of conversion attest, they too struggled with the contradictory demands of submission and action. My answer to the question of the agency "trap" draws on Talal Asad: What does it mean to write histories of submission and willing powerlessness?³⁵

KAREN VALLGÅRDA

My academic upbringing took place in the early 2000s, and this involved a poststructuralist education that insisted on our obligation to probe the politics of knowledge. We were to become aware of the political implications our own knowledge production, of the questions we asked, of our epistemological assumptions and the analytical categories we employed. While it has sometimes bothered me how the endless deconstructive efforts seemed to direct analytical attention away from other forms of critical analyses—such as studies of economic exploitation or physical violence—the insight that no category is neutral remains crucial.

In postcolonial studies—my first research field—scholars argued forcefully that we should abandon attempts to search for untainted subaltern voices.³⁶ By extension, "agency" was thoroughly problematized as a concept that might help us examine relationships of power in a useful way. Coming to childhood studies, I was therefore surprised to find that demonstrating children's agency still figured as a sort of gold standard of the field.

In my view, the concept of agency is fundamentally flawed, theoretically and analytically. It rests on the supposition, inherited from Enlightenment thinkers, that the individual is an autonomous actor: the individual's capacity to act may be constrained by outside forces, limited by lack of economic or social resources, or obstructed by an inferior position in a social hierarchy, but at least theoretically, the individual's interests, desires, and apprehensions might be identified as distinct and distinguishable from their surroundings. For the historian, to document human agency in the past means to trace how an individual or a group acted to further their own interests, however circumscribed their maneuvering space may have been.

What might be less obvious is that agency is tied to a particular liberalist understanding of the human activity and interaction. As historian of slavery Walter Johnson argued in his seminal piece, the concept smuggles into historical studies a "liberal notion of selfhood, with its emphasis on independence and choice." It relies on "a rational choice model of human being" in which the autonomous subject is motivated by the pursuit of individual interest.³⁷

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Agency is thus connected to a neoliberal conception of human dignity and worth; a valorization of the individual who exercises free will and who is productive, culturally, socially, and economically. But the idea that human worth hinges upon one's ability to act deliberately to optimize one's own situation is inherently hierarchical. The fact that we don't find it necessary to demonstrate the agency of socially privileged groups indicates that the quest to affirm the agency of enslaved people or other subaltern groups is a rather skewed project.

Relatively unpowerful individuals or communities will ultimately have less agency and, by implication, less humanity. We might, in other words, unintentionally end up suggesting that the free, able-bodied, cisgender, heterosexual, wealthy, middle-aged, white man somehow had greater human worth than less privileged subjects did.

This critique is highly relevant in the context of the history of childhood and youth. The actor, as Mary Jo Maynes has noted, "is posited as everything a child, especially a girl child, is not supposed to be: autonomous, driven by the imperatives of rational choice, aware of how the world works."³⁸ Perhaps where agency begins conceptually is where childhood ends.³⁹

There are many possible ways out of the agency trap; we need not abandon the ambition to explore the perspectives of children and youth as historical subjects. My own approach has been to historicize agency as a concept, examining how historical contingencies such as age, gender, sexuality, race, and religion helped produce or impede what was perceived to be agency in different contexts.⁴⁰ Importantly, I study how desires, apprehensions, interests, and hence subjectivities were shaped through historical processes, keeping in mind the power dynamics that these involved. The history of emotions and experience have provided fruitful ways into this endeavor.⁴¹ Kristine Alexander, Stephanie Olsen, and I suggested that the structural process through which emotions are shaped may be conceived of as an "emotional formation" and that the confrontation between dissimilar emotional formations constitutes an "emotional frontier."⁴²

Moving away from attempts to locate authentic, untainted voices from the past or to identify agency, Katrine Rønsig Larsen and I have furthermore coined the concept of emotional echoing to identify a key aspect of emotional formation. Homing in on the ongoing human efforts to make sense of, classify, direct, anchor, and communicate experiences, we posit that to know and to enact our emotions—that is, *to feel*—humans of all ages employ the available cultural templates of emotionality. This implies citing and reiterating—or echoing—other people's body language as well as visual and verbal vocabulary. Emotional echoing is the process through which individuals employ words,

images, and practices borrowed from a cultural repertoire; emotive tools that they thereby help replicate and adapt. It molds a person's emotional capacities and shapes their subjectivity. Echoing, put differently, has to do with the continuous becoming of the individual subject through exchanges with collective forms of feeling.⁴³

Emotional echoes are traceable across a variety of sources—visual, textual, and even material. Hopefully, it will prove a useful tool in our quest to approximate the experiences, feelings, and interventions of young people in the past, with a systematic view to how these were conditioned by—and contributed to—variegated dynamics of power.

NOTES

1. Mona Gleason "Avoiding the Agency Trap: Caveats for Historians of Children, Youth, and Education," *History of Education* 45, no. 4 (2016): 446–59; Kristine Alexander, "Agency and Emotion Work," *Jeunesse: Young People, Texts, Cultures* 7, no. 2 (2015): 120–28; Susan A. Miller, "Assent as Agency in the Early Years of the Children of the American Revolution," *Journal of the History of Childhood and Youth* 9, no. 1 (2016): 48–65.
2. Walter Johnson, "On Agency," *Journal of Social History* 37 (2003): 113–24; Lynn M. Thomas, "Historicising Agency," *Gender & History* 28, no. 2 (2016): 324–39.
3. Sarah Maza, "The Kids Aren't All Right: Historians and the Problem of Childhood," *American Historical Review* 125, no. 4 (2020): 1261–85; responses by several historians of childhood and youth, including Ishita Pande, "Is the History of Childhood Ready for the World? A Response to 'The Kids Aren't All Right,'" *American Historical Review* 125, no. 4 (2020): 1300–05, 1302.
4. <https://events.tuni.fi/historyofexperience2021/panels/theme-4-childhood-and-youth/>.
5. For a recent overview of what the new history of experiences is and is not, see Josephine Hoegaerts and Stephanie Olsen, "The History of Experience: Afterword," in *Lived Nation as the History of Experiences and Emotions in Finland, 1800–2000*, eds. Ville Kivimäki, Sami Suodenjoki, and Tanja Vahtikari (Cham: Palgrave, 2021), 382, and 380–82 on the specific relationship between the history of children and childhood and the history of experiences.
6. Kristine Moruzi, Nell Musgrove, and Carla Pascoe Leahy, eds. *Children's Voices from the Past: New Historical and Interdisciplinary Perspectives* (Cham: Palgrave MacMillan, 2019).
7. See <https://events.tuni.fi/historyofexperience/keynotes/mona-gleason-agency-experience-and-the-challenge-of-historical-significance/>; Mona Gleason, "'Children Obviously Don't Make History': Historical Significance and Children's Modalities of Power," *Journal of the History of Childhood and Youth* 16, no. 3 (2023): 343–60.
8. Rob Boddice and Mark Smith, *Emotion, Sense, Experience* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2020), 22–23.
9. Mary Jo Maynes, "Age as a Category of Historical Analysis: History, Agency, and Narratives of Childhood," *Journal of the History of Childhood and Youth* 1, no. 1 (2008): 114–24.
10. Thomas, "Historicising Agency," 327.